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Yazan Zahzah

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Yazan Zahzah

Women's and Gender Studies Department, San Diego State University, San Diego, CA, USA

ABSTRACT

This essay utilizes a transnational framework to introduce the concept of warcare, which I define as the co-constitutive relationship between humanitarian work and counterinsurgency, by exploring the enactment of Countering Violent Extremism (CVE) counterinsurgency in San Diego as an extension of the U.S. War on Terror. I identify the rhetoric put forth by CVE programming and examine the material impact its programming has on refugees in the U.S. as well as communities in countries militarized by the United States. In doing so, I analyze the symbiotic relationship between militarization, displacement, and humanitarian work.

KEYWORDS

Warcare; militarized refugees; surveillance; counterinsurgency

The Higgins fired 23 Tomahawk missiles from the North Arabian Gulf at three targets in Syria that the Pentagon said were fundamental to the regime's chemical warfare infrastructure ... Together, we have sent a clear message to Assad ...”

– Andrew Nguyen, “Local San Diego Destroyer USS Higgins Used in Attack Against Syria” (April 14 2018)¹

The Syrian refugee in a leopard print hijab and denim jacket is learning to drive for the first time in her life. The mother of four is one of twelve women in the inaugural cohort of “Women at the Wheel,” the unique initiative ... that provides ten hours of Drivers Ed for free to female refugees ... [It] strives to improve the lives of refugees from war-torn countries by empowering families themselves to move toward self-sufficiency and independence ...

– Tarryn Mento, “Drivers Ed Helps Women Refugees Navigate Road to Self-Sufficiency” (October 18 2018)²

At first glance, the quotes cited above might seem to be at odds with one another, the first depicting the spectacular violence of overt militarism and the second the benevolence of good-faith humanitarianism. However, by taking a deeper look at the logics and tactics that have long animated the War on Terror, what appears on the surface as antithetical is revealed to be co-constitutive. The U.S. bombings of Syria in 2018 and this “Women at the Wheel” empowerment initiative are two examples of warcare as they stem from the exact same governmental source: The Bureau of Counterterrorism and Countering Violent Extremism (CVE). This deliberate juxtaposition, therefore, illustrates the relationship between U.S. militarization – a primary agent of global displacement – and counterinsurgent social welfare programming for refugees from Muslim-majority countries residing in

San Diego, California. Herein lies the important relationship between war strategies and care economies, what I refer to as *warcare economies*.

I write as a community organizer who has done collaborative work with Syrian, Iraqi, and Palestinian refugees (or refugees from the Levant) as well as East African refugees, primarily from Somalia, residing in San Diego, whose lives have long been impacted by “warcare.” My work is concerned with how U.S. militarization, U.S. humanitarian aid, community policing, domestic surveillance, counterinsurgency, and conditional social welfare impact the lives of Muslim refugees who are simultaneously positioned as racialized targets of the War on Terror and subjects in need of saving.

While frameworks exploring the prison- and terror-industrial complexes allow us to make sense of the experience of Muslim refugees impacted by federal repression in the United States, warcare necessitates a transnational examination of humanitarianism as it intersects with counterinsurgency operations and militarized violence. It forces us to consider the experience of militarized refugees in tandem with U.S. war economies.³ Drawing on a Critical Refugee Studies tradition, the incorporation of push factors – militarization and counterinsurgency – allows for a more comprehensive understanding of the unique position endured by refugees from Muslim-majority countries as they are suspended between U.S. militarization of their homelands and conditional humanitarianism in their resettlement sites, in this particular context, San Diego, California.⁴ While examining civil rights abuses of Muslim refugees in the U.S. is vital, without locating such violations within the complex network of militarization and empire, we unwittingly ignore the ways in which refugee care economies, too, are rooted in rights abuse, violence, and displacement.

San Diego was one of the first cities to accept refugees en masse following the United States’ war in Vietnam. A national infrastructure to facilitate this process – the Office of Refugee Resettlement (ORR) – was formed shortly after the war and was arguably an attempt to compensate for the inability of the U.S. to defeat communism in the twentieth century.⁵ Following the war, San Diego became a central hub for refugee resettlement. Over the last three decades, the city has continued to serve as a refugee resettlement hub and has accepted large numbers of Somali, Syrian, and Iraqi refugees. Surges in migration from each community directly correlate with climaxes of U.S. militarization in each country. As a result, San Diego is of particular interest to the Department of Homeland Security (DHS) due to its relatively large Somali, Syrian, and Iraqi Muslim populations. While the social, religious, and political alignments of all these communities are diverse, Islamophobic racialization has led DHS programmers to categorize both City Heights and El Cajon – homes to major refugee communities in San Diego – as unilateral security threats “prone to radicalization.” To understand warcare economies as they pertain to refugees from Muslim majority countries in San Diego, this essay will focus primarily on the relationship between violence prevention framework programming popularized by institutions worldwide for decades, their counterinsurgent undertones requiring collusion with varied government data collection and intelligence gathering agencies, and the corresponding militarization of Muslim-majority countries by the U.S.

U.S. Empire and CVE

Countering Violent Extremism⁶ efforts are best understood as counterinsurgent social welfare programming. They typically purport to be genial initiatives cultivated in service

of the well-being of what they regard to be “at-risk” communities – most often working-class refugee Muslim communities in the U.S. and poor Muslim communities in countries abroad. CVE architects claim that by providing necessary resources and integrating violence-prevention educational trainings into community social and spiritual spaces, the program can simultaneously operate as a watchful eye through which its leaders can predict which members of a community are prone to so-called violent extremism in order to preemptively curtail it. CVE relies on indicators that have identified religiosity, political values, mental health, socioeconomic class, and gender as predictors of the propensity to “extremist” violence. Its social service programming includes vocational workshops targeting women and children, distribution of relief resources such as diapers and hygiene kits, creative programming for youth, police-youth collaborations, “peacemaking” workshops, and other nonprofit programming that uses themes of empowerment, feminism, and wellness. Placing a crucial emphasis on the provision of resources and care, CVE presents itself as a program of benevolent humanitarianism in part to obscure its programmatic collaboration with federal bodies such as DHS, the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI), the Department of Justice (DOJ), the U.S. military, and other entities culpable in the mass repression of the same communities they service.

Fundamental to grasping the relationship between CVE and Muslim refugees is the understanding that humanitarianism is not contrary to militarism but often a complementary feature. NGO economies depend on conflict and community poverty for their survival. David Miliband, the CEO of the International Rescue Committee (IRC), one of the world’s largest nonprofits geared toward servicing refugees and migrants, gave a TED talk in 2017 on the ongoing refugee crises around the world. Miliband stated that the three major issues that push migrants to flee their home countries are local governmental failures, international weakness, and local religious conflict. Western militarization, exploitative trade agreements, and resource deprivation were not considered push factors in his framework. Similarly, when examining military operations in conjunction with CVE initiatives, it becomes apparent that there is a strong correlation between where CVE programming is offered by agencies like the United States Agency for International Development (USAID) or the United Nations (UN) and where U.S. military personnel are currently stationed.⁷ Whether looking at East Africa, the Levant, or South Asia, it becomes clear that where the United States military has a base, CVE activities are typically present.⁸ “Peacekeeping missions” currently in operation by the U.S. military reveal that while the domestic CVE budget is tens of millions of dollars, the transnational total of CVE-related budgeting runs in the billions.⁹ Furthermore, refugees the United States accepts – typically, those fleeing political violence caused in part by U.S. intervention – result in budget allotments per head per state that typically run in the millions of dollars. Last but certainly not least, the refugee populations identified as targets by CVE in the U.S. usually come from East Africa, the Levant, South Asia, Afghanistan, or East Asia, specifically the countries impacted by U.S. militarization and transnational CVE programming through the War on Terror.

CVE programmers use a combination of funding, training, and law enforcement partnerships to gain access to community spaces with two primary goals. First, these programs typically prioritize normalizing relationships between government officials and law enforcement agencies complicit in racialized surveillance, displacement, and violence with the very communities they target. Second, these programs use the illusion of benevolent, good-

faith humanitarianism to build trust with community members, encouraging support for patriotic agendas to freely access intel. In turn, communities believe there is a safe space and open up, as programmers identify political threats and criminalize the opinions and actions of those presumed threats. If we take the experience of the Syrian woman in the opening narrative, the U.S. military has been involved in Syria for many years and U.S. NGOs have had programming in Syria and Syrian refugee camps in Jordan and Lebanon just as long, while there is U.S.-based CVE programming for Syrian refugees across the country.¹⁰

While the U.S. has a heavy hand in the displacement, decimation, and day-to-day struggles of refugees, it has constructed a global network of partnerships and programs which bureaucratically funnel displaced peoples through various institutions. The paradox of the approach is a generative element of imperial hegemony: it obfuscates statecraft violence even as it creates it, consequently avoiding accountability in the name of care. Such an insidious strategy continues to roll out in CVE funding pools, institutional partnership agreements, and memorandums of understandings between the private and public sectors. These programs continue to affect the lives of everyday people who have already endured unimaginable violence, especially the lives of refugee women from Muslim-majority countries residing in San Diego at any point in this process. If there is material political resistance vocalized or enacted, they are subject to counterinsurgency or criminal punishment.

Violence prevention and autonomous struggles

Counterterrorism has been part of violence-prevention strategies popularized by global institutions for decades. At the heart of prevention frameworks are the depoliticization and individualization of violence. Such an approach assumes that lack of self-esteem, a poor sense of personal worth, cultural isolation, and individual mental health are the primary drivers of extremism. For example, political frustration, religiosity, and social isolation were among the diagnoses listed to justify the necessity for CVE programming as an antidote to radicalization in San Diego. In particular, the “significance quest hypothesis” was a social science theory cited by the University of San Diego in a 2016 Countering Violent Extremism grant application to the Department of Homeland Security.¹¹ Developed by national security scholars conducting studies in Al-Khalil, Palestine, the premise of this theory alleges that youth become extremists due to the lack of self-esteem, friendships, or material wealth. Such a framework contends that violence can be prevented if one is isolated from radical politics, assimilated into normative societal structures, and under careful watch of community-policing collaborations. In this context, violence – identified as ideologically motivated individual aggression – can be mitigated by surveillance and policing tactics. This framework claims to prevent violence by providing social services and building community relations. It forms the heart of the programming offered by Countering Violent Extremism (CVE), Targeted Violence Terrorism Prevention (TVTP), Center for Prevention Programs and Partnerships (CP3), PREVENT, and Women, Peace, & Security (WPS), which are distinct but overlapping projects in international law, policy, funding, and partnerships housed in the U.S. federal government, the United Nations, the UK, as well as other governments and militaries worldwide.

Violence prevention frameworks rely heavily on apolitical and ahistorical identifiers that reduce violence to depraved individual actions. By design, the actions of national

governments, federal bureaus, military, or police are not considered sources of ideological violence that act in ways necessitating self-defense from non-state actors. For example, the studies that informed the significance quest prevention theory do not reference Zionist militarization as a push factor of “extremism.” Al-Khalil is one of the strongholds of Palestinian resistance and many youth have joined operations targeting Zionist control of Palestinian life, a crucial detail warped by the social science study. Overall, under the guise of violence prevention frameworks, Zionist and U.S. militarization are not categorized as violence because Zionist militarization is framed as legitimate self-defense from Palestinian depravity and U.S. militarization is typically coded as care for communities impacted by globalization, war, and localized repression. For example, Iraqis living in San Diego today do so due to U.S. intervention in Iraq, yet patriotic discourse frames this intervention as a reprieve from otherwise undemocratic rule, regardless of the U.S.’s role in instigating the war or their culpability in the gore of Abu Ghraib.

Without acknowledging state culpability in forcing migration, prevention frameworks in turn delegitimize non-state responses to state and colonial militarization – critique, political dissent, protest, or armed resistance – by attributing them to individual instability, religious fanaticism, or personal gain. In Somalia, for instance, repeated clashes between U.S.-backed militaries, United States personnel, and armed non-state militias forced many Somalis to flee to the U.S. in the 1990s, with many refugees ending up in San Diego and non-state militias blamed as the source of the tensions that necessitated imperial intervention. As they have done with their framings of East Africa, congressional panels deliberating on the expansion of CVE-related programming have described Iran as “a primary impediment to achieving peace in an absolutely critical region” due to its “support for Hezbollah, for Hamas, and for a number of smaller Palestinian rejectionist groups.” They have also expressed “concern about their efforts to engage in all kinds of destabilization.”¹² Absent in the discussion is the recognition that U.S. militarization and the economic exploitation of Iran, Lebanon, Syria, and Palestine have created millions of refugees, let alone the U.S.’s pivotal role in supporting Zionist hegemonic control of the region. Iran, Syria, and Hezbollah were active opponents of the U.S. when military aggression against Syria was at its highest; it is these clashes that contributed to waves of refugees to flee Syria with a majority of U.S.-bound refugees ending up in San Diego.

Refugees in the U.S. have been criminalized for alleged involvement with non-state actors abroad. In San Diego and other cities across the U.S., Somali community members have been subjects of state-sponsored spying and surveillance programs for decades. In San Diego, federal agents have accumulated a vast watchlist that includes prominent Somali leaders, while community remittances have been closely surveilled as well.¹³ In 2007, phone tapping – a secret spying method legalized by the USA PATRIOT ACT – was used to record conversations between religious leaders and key community members profiled for their opposition to the U.S.-backed Ethiopian invasion of Somalia. Four community members were ultimately arrested, tried, and convicted of allegedly providing material support to Al Shabaab, a militant group actively fighting against Ethiopia in Somalia. This case gained notoriety due to its reliance on NSA data collection; however, it is only one of dozens of secret spying operations that San Diego’s Muslim refugee population have endured. In some cases, people as young as 25, have been being incarcerated for sending a few hundred dollars to alleged Al Shabaab affiliates in their homeland.¹⁴ Syrian refugees in San Diego, too, have

many experiences with surveillance and repression mirroring the aforementioned experiences of Somali refugees.

Still, it is important to note that while repression against Muslim refugees in San Diego County has increased tremendously with programs like CVE, there is ample community awareness of the dangers posed by the program and other surveillance initiatives. Many community members and organizations have challenged the incorporation of CVE into nonprofit programming by vocally speaking out against CVE facilitators at community events, changing where they seek services when able, and self-advocating at city and county meetings where policing and surveillance measures are being discussed.

Juxtaposing these examples, it becomes clear that through a violence prevention framework, there is a clear-cut way to classify and criminalize the politicized actions of individuals from a racialized base while entirely overlooking the political actions of entire nations with exponentially more influence, resources, and impact. Religiosity and political ideologies harbored by Muslim refugees critical of ongoing state-sponsored violence that has actively destabilized their homelands, displaced them, and left immeasurable impacts of colonial violence abroad, are deemed illegitimate. Meanwhile the U.S.-backed East African militarization of Somalia or U.S.-Zionist militarization of Syria are not only seen as legitimate, but as the hegemonic force in determining the legitimacy of imperial violence. It leads to an important interrogation of how the legal rubric of terrorism cannot be applied to ideologically motivated state-sponsored imperialist invasions, economic coercion, and militarized violence, as well as, most importantly, whether or not what is defined as terrorism is in fact a legitimate barometer of what constitutes violence in the first place.

Gender and CVE

CVE prevention frameworks selectively invoke gender to promote liberal feminist frameworks selectively identifying women as victims, extremists, or potential catalysts for “change” in their communities. Women, Peace, and Security is a CVE-adjacent framework that expands on these concepts in detail. Essential to understanding CVE is recognizing that while there is a seemingly progressive nod to gender and women’s empowerment, the end-goal is always the promotion of U.S.-aligned agendas as well as the pacification of resistance.

For example, the driving program referenced at the opening of this essay was previously offered by a nonprofit deeply embroiled in intra-community tensions due to its normalized relationships with Zionist organizations, its objectification of Syrian refugees, and its alleged collusion with DHS. Many programs offered by this nonprofit organization offered women-only vocational programming, a popular tactic of counterterrorism efforts to isolate women from their communities. A similar program was being offered in a Syrian refugee camp in Lebanon that taught women English while simultaneously including tips and talking points on how to identify the radicalization of family and friends. This program was offered in partnership with the International Rescue Committee (IRC), which has offices all over the world, including San Diego. In San Diego, the IRC is one of the county’s oldest and most widely used nonprofits for refugee services, offering support to dozens of refugee communities.

San Diego’s counterterrorist violence prevention programming also maintains a global arm through the University of San Diego. The university has offered a fellowship called Women PeaceMakers for over 20 years which accepts women from all over the world

currently engaged in “peacemaking” projects, often, one might argue, in collusion with the CVE interests of the United States, the United Nations, or their own national governments. For instance, Mossarat Qadeem, a recipient of a Women PeaceKeepers fellowship, is a foundational figure in enacting CVE programming in Pakistan through her nonprofit work identifying mothers as agents responsible for stopping “extremists,” who are typically individuals carrying out operations challenging Pakistani and U.S. army presence in poor and repressed neighborhoods of Pakistan. She has previously acted at the behest of the U.S.-backed Pakistani military to do so.¹⁵ Fellows sponsored by the institution include Rina Kedem, a Zionist-Israeli environmentalist who has used liberal environmentalism to promote normalization efforts. On the whole, the program has typically referenced the pacification of armed militias, normalization between marginalized groups and national governments, and the acceptance of UN governance in describing the types of projects it supports.

The fundamental tension of programming like this is it fills a vacuum typically experienced by poor Muslim refugees or poor Muslim communities abroad, especially women: drivers’ licenses, vocational training, English language classes, or community spaces at no cost to the community are all fundamental assets to refugees starting over in new countries or communities enduring ongoing war. Thus, while these programs are presented as depoliticized or genial, there is a precise exploitation of material need that leverages political control – it is warfare.

CVE and repression

There is a long history between U.S. militarism, humanitarian work, and political repression. The repression of communities targeted by CVE programming has not lessened despite the implication that the existence of violence prevention programming is meant to replace carceral rigidity. If anything, these instances have only increased. Islamophobic and xenophobic harassment against Muslim youth in schools has increased tremendously with minimal reprieve as the ideological underpinnings of this violence is fundamentally beyond the scope of violence prevention programming, let alone its integral role to U.S. patriotism.¹⁶ Court cases profiling Muslim religiosity and anti-imperialism, like the ones discussed previously, have also seen an exponential rise in the U.S., especially youth trials alleging online radicalization. Between 2017 and 2018, investigations by civil rights groups revealed that nearly 200 East African refugee men were unlawfully detained, tortured, and sexually abused by a combination of ICE agents and officers in private detention centers.¹⁷

Today, CVE and related anti-terrorism prevention initiatives have provided hundreds of millions of dollars to community organizations, universities, nonprofits, police departments, intelligence agencies, and armies around the world geared toward enacting programs securing intelligence on targeted communities, while simultaneously surveilling, policing, arresting, and killing “terrorists” – typically non-state actors critical of U.S. militarism and political control. When we consider the criminalization of anti-imperialism and anti-Zionism (especially when looking at the criminalization of Iran, Hamas, and Hezbollah in CVE literature), it reveals the sizable profits reaped from cyclical wars, migration, repression, surveillance, and counterinsurgency. With the recent withdrawal of U.S. forces from Afghanistan, USAID – a major enactor of global CVE programming – has pledged it will remain regardless of the U.S. military presence in Afghanistan, a contemporary reflection of the complex intersection between war, humanitarian work,

counterinsurgency, and impacted community members.¹⁸ By broadening our analysis to incorporate the many layers of war, migration, and repression, we will be able to make more calculated gains in our struggle against hegemonic violence.

Notes

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Disclosure statement

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Notes on contributor

Yazan Zahzah is a community-based researcher and organizer from Southern California, currently working as a lecturer for the California State University system. Yazan's research examines the relationship between war, migration, surveillance, and social welfare programming. Yazan is the Community Organizer at Vigilant Love in Los Angeles, CA and a longtime member of the Palestinian Youth Movement, a grassroots organization dedicated to the self-determination of the Palestinian People.